

GREATER CLEVELAND MUSIC CENSUS



Photo Courtesy of Cleveland Rocks Past, Present, Future

SUMMARY REPORT
2024

 **SOUND MUSIC CITIES**

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Executive Summary

The Greater Cleveland Music Census is a community-led initiative to gain a better understanding of the current needs of the Cleveland-area music community. This marks the first time in over a decade that the music community will have new data from 2,768 respondents from which to develop policy solutions and approaches. The 2023 study was led by Cleveland Rocks: Past, Present, Future and The Cleveland Independent Venue Association, with support from the Cleveland Foundation.

Across 10 key indicator areas, Cleveland is a relatively healthy music ecosystem. The Cleveland music ecosystem is mostly balanced across creatives (74%), industry (18%), and venue/presenters (8%). Cleveland has a decent industry segment which offers its ecosystem a competitive advantage over places lacking this infrastructure. Increasing the venue/presenters portion slightly to support the creatives with more opportunities to perform may bring more balance.

Most respondents (76%) would like to see Cleveland create a music commission at the city or county level. The focus of such a commission would be live entertainment programming, creative grants, audience development, ecosystem support, and live entertainment-friendly regulatory improvements.

Cleveland's diverse musical genres span rock, classical, jazz, pop, and R&B/hip hop. Creatives rely primarily on local gigs for income, while other sources like touring and studio work are less substantial; there is a need for diversification of revenue streams. The majority of venue/presenter respondents identify as live music venues or independent promoters offering an extensive live music scene. Venues average 91 live events/year for a total of 14,762 total live events. Primary industry occupations for respondents include event/venue worker, music marketing, and production support.

Cleveland music people reported an average household income of \$82K. Of this income, 26% or an average annual income of \$21K, is earned from music work. Across all respondents, music makers generate a total of \$58 million dollars in income annually. Yet, the workforce is still primarily freelance and independent, with 65% of respondents working another job outside of music. Only 17% of respondents have received any form of financial assistance, so a range of grants, tax breaks, or incentives could further increase the local economy of the Cleveland music ecosystem.

Cleveland respondents find it very livable, noting some affordability issues. A super majority plan to keep working in music and stay in Cleveland. In terms of culture and belonging, the Cleveland music ecosystem is somewhat challenged by elitism, ageism, and ableism, but on the positive side, a majority of respondents experience the Cleveland music ecosystem as safe, diverse, and inclusive. Cleveland would do well to enhance efforts to support underrepresented groups and foster a collaborative environment, reducing competitiveness and exclusivity. Respondents want to connect with other creative industries, with music services, and to collaborate musically.

This report and the online dashboard available at www.ClevelandRocksPPF.org offer more in-depth data, insights, and opportunities to further develop the vibrant Cleveland music ecosystem and all the benefits it offers economically and culturally.

Introduction

The Greater Cleveland Music Census is a community-led initiative to gain a better understanding of the current needs of the Cleveland-area music community. The Census captures key information about the Cleveland music economy to help the city and community make more informed, data-driven decisions to support the music ecosystem. This marks the first time in almost a decade that the music community will have new data from which to develop policy solutions and approaches.

The 2023 Greater Cleveland Music Census was administered by Sound Music Cities a leading Austin-based provider of music ecosystem studies and music census work, in conjunction with Cleveland Rocks: Past, Present, Future and The Cleveland Independent Venue Association, as well as support from local partners. The Census was made possible with financial support from The Cleveland Foundation. Cleveland joined a multi-city cohort offering ongoing collaborative sessions with many other major cities conducting similar research.

This summary report has been prepared by Sound Music Cities and includes an overview of the Music Ecosystem Health Assessment based on 10 key indicator areas. The report includes key findings and recommendations. Alongside this report, Sound Music Cities has provided access to an online dashboard where you can find more data at www.ClevelandRocksPPF.org.

INTRODUCTION TO A MUSIC CENSUS

Any strategy to support and grow a music ecosystem begins with a basic understanding of its population. Professional music communities are not easily discoverable using traditional methods (such as through labor statistics or economic data). A music census collects key data points to better understand music people and their economic activity within a specific geography. It provides a baseline for policymakers and the larger community to understand and take action.

The value of a music census goes well beyond the data itself. Such initiatives ignite a range of activities that are conducive to more strategic and sustainable support for local music scenes over the long term, beginning with validating this economically marginalized group, sharing new learning, activating civic and community resources, and ultimately empowering music people to take ownership of change initiatives.

2,768 responses

November 8 - December 15, 2023

8% venue/presenter

18% industry

74% music creatives



Photos Courtesy of Cleveland Rocks Past, Present, Future

A Community Effort

The 2023 study was led by Cleveland Rocks: Past, Present, Future and The Cleveland Independent Venue Association, with support from the Cleveland Foundation. This study took a grassroots approach that engaged local partners who hold the relationships with music people. Community Partners and Ambassadors served as the primary means of outreach to music people and these organizations were instrumental in shaping the census itself.

We thank our amazing Community Partners & Artist Ambassadors

COMMUNITY PARTNERS

A to Z Audio
 Assembly for the Arts
 Audio Alchemy Studio
 Axon Creative Agency
 B-W Music Industry Program
 Bad Racket LLC
 Beachland Ballroom
 BOP STOP at The Music Settlement
 Carnelian Productions LLC
 City of Cleveland
 Clair Global
 Cleveland Blues Society
 Cleveland Classical Guitar Society
 Cleveland Cultural Gardens
 Cleveland Foundation
 Cleveland MIC: Music Industry Conversations
 Cleveland Museum of Art
 Cleveland Pops Orchestra, Bascom Little Fund
 Cleveland Scoring / Heights Theater
 Cleveland Time Records
 Cleveland Uncommon Sound Project (CUSP)
 Cool Cleveland
 cowntownchad photography
 Cuyahoga County
 Dark Current Productions
 Destination Cleveland
 Gotta Groove Records, Inc
 Gray Panther Media
 Greater Cleveland Creative
 Grog Shop
 Happy Dog
 Heights Arts
 Jib Machine Records
 Kaboom Collective
 Lake Affect Studios
 Larchmere PorchFest
 Legendary Communications and Promotions
 ListenCLE
 Little Fish Records
 Local 4 Union
 Magnetic North Studio
 Music Box Supper Club
 Music on a Mission

National Cleveland-Style Polka Hall of Fame and Museum
 No Surf House
 Northeast Ohio Musical Heritage Association
 Odd Block Entertainment / Mannequin Odd Studio and Production
 Panza Foundation
 Piano Cleveland
 Pickwick & Frolic
 ProShow Sound LLC
 RAMPD.org
 Rock and Roll Hall of Fame
 Roots of American Music
 School Of Rock
 Sip & Spin
 Sombrero Brothers Productions, LLC
 Spotlight Cleveland
 Suma Recording
 Temple Live
 TERRA Songwriting
 The Agora
 The Cleveland Orchestra
 The Foundry Concert Club
 The Treelawn
 The Violet Edge
 Vertical Sound

AMBASSADORS

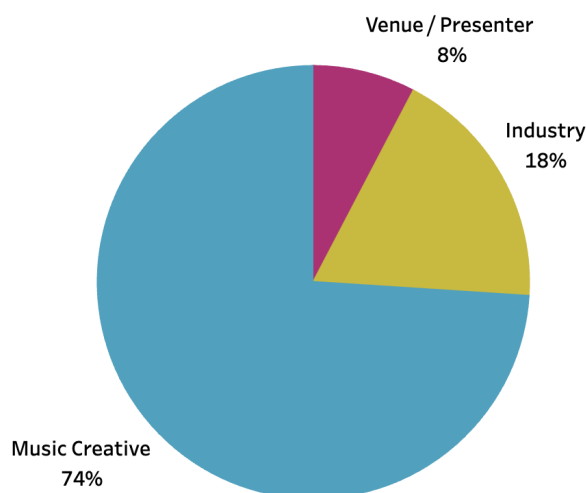
2Reel Music Entertainment	Kerri Whitehouse
Angie Younessi	Kevin Brosien
Big in Japan	MusiCLE and MusiCLE2
Big North Entertainment	Old No. 55 Band
Cal Zunt	Pierced Poets' Productions
Chris Abood	Punky Floyd
Cleveland Music Scene Coalition	Red Eye Gin
DaLo Ent	Robbing Mary
Doug Wood	Rotatori Consulting
Hum and Strum, Coventry Ukulele Club	RPM Productions
JABradley Photography	Sherrie Lynn Communications, LLC
Jay Minkin	Steve Blu Goebel
Jay Wallace	Sunflurry
Jerry Popiel	Super Critical Learning Foundation
John Harrow	The Elite Team Entertainment LLC
John Kovach	Waylon Fingers
Kate Sopko	Zone Music Inc. (Humachine)

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Ecosystem Composition

Across the 2,768 respondents, the Cleveland music ecosystem enjoys a healthy balance across creatives (74%), industry (18%), and venue/presenters (8%). We like to see industry closer to 20%, but this is nearly there. Increasing the venue/presenters portion slightly to support the creatives may bring more balance.

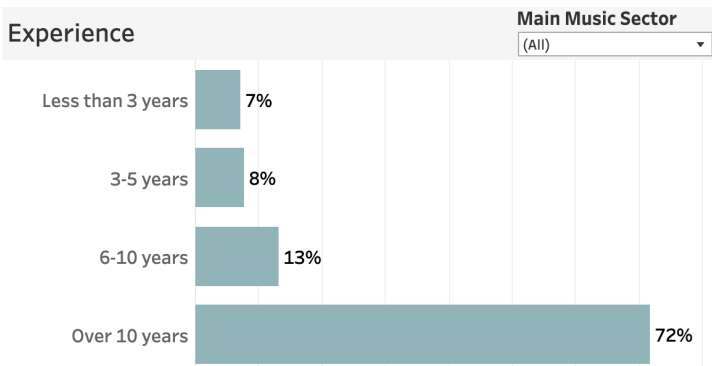
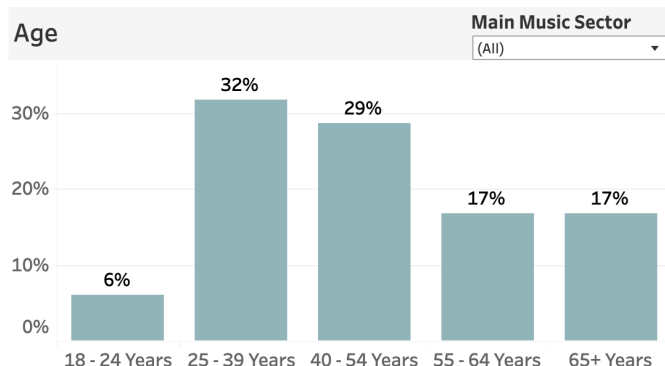
- **Race** - Leans heavily towards White/European representation, with 86% of respondents falling into this category, consistent with trends in other cities. However, Black, African, and African American representation is 13%, below the city's general population. Hispanic representation stands at just 3%, indicating a 4% gap compared to the general population. Efforts to enhance diversity and inclusion, particularly among Black, African, African American, and Hispanic communities, are necessary for a more representative music scene.



- **Age** - Healthy distribution. 25-29 group is the highest segment among all respondents. 40-54 group is highest among the venue/presenter respondents. We would like to see a little higher in the 18-24 range.

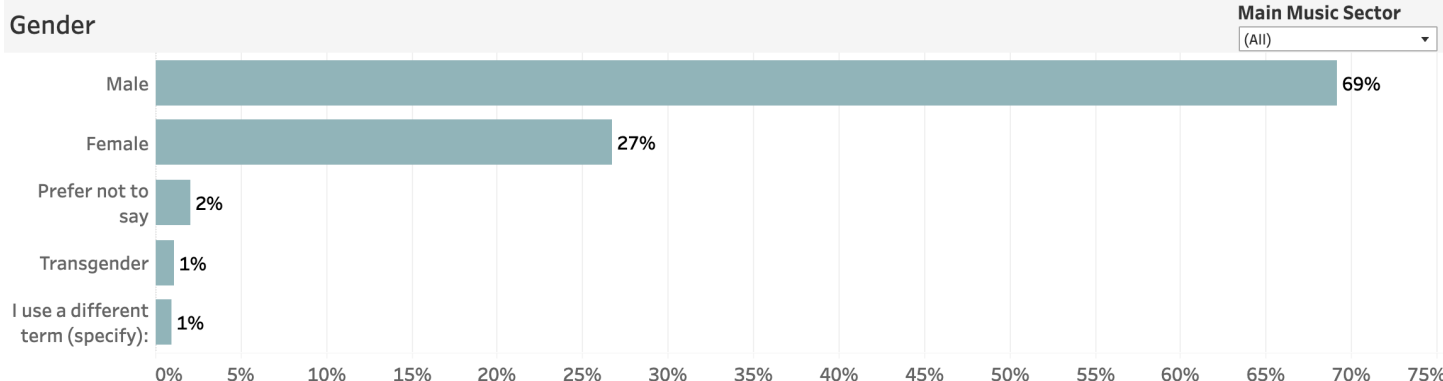
- **Experience** - Across all respondents, 7% report having less than three years of experience in the music industry. While the industry sector displays a more balanced distribution of experience levels, the creative sector is less so, with 75% boasting over 10 years of experience. Overall, this indicates a level of sustainability within the ecosystem, although efforts are needed to ensure a more equitable distribution of opportunities for emerging talent.

Race & Ethnicity									
White/ European Origin	Black, African or African American	Two or more races	Hispanic	Asian or Asian American	Native American or Alaska Native	Native Hawaiian or Pacific Islan..			
86%									
	68%								
		19%							
	6%								
		4%							
		4%							
			3%						
			7%						
				1%					
				3%					
					0%				
					0%				
						0%			
							0%		

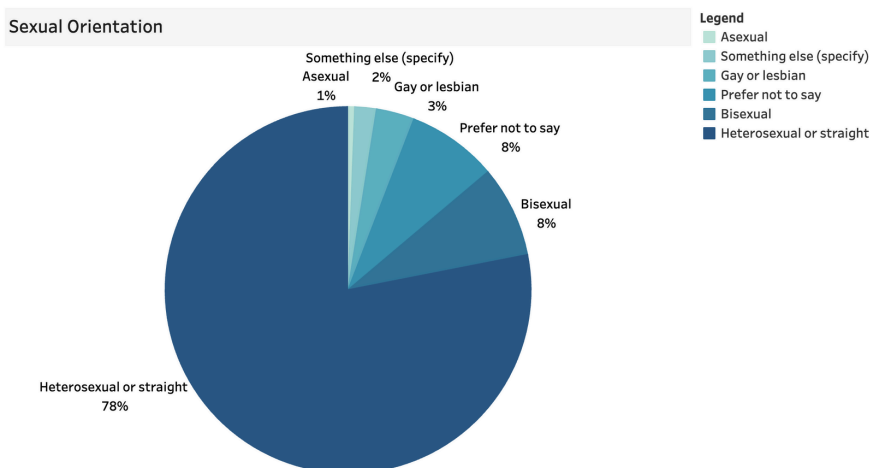


Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

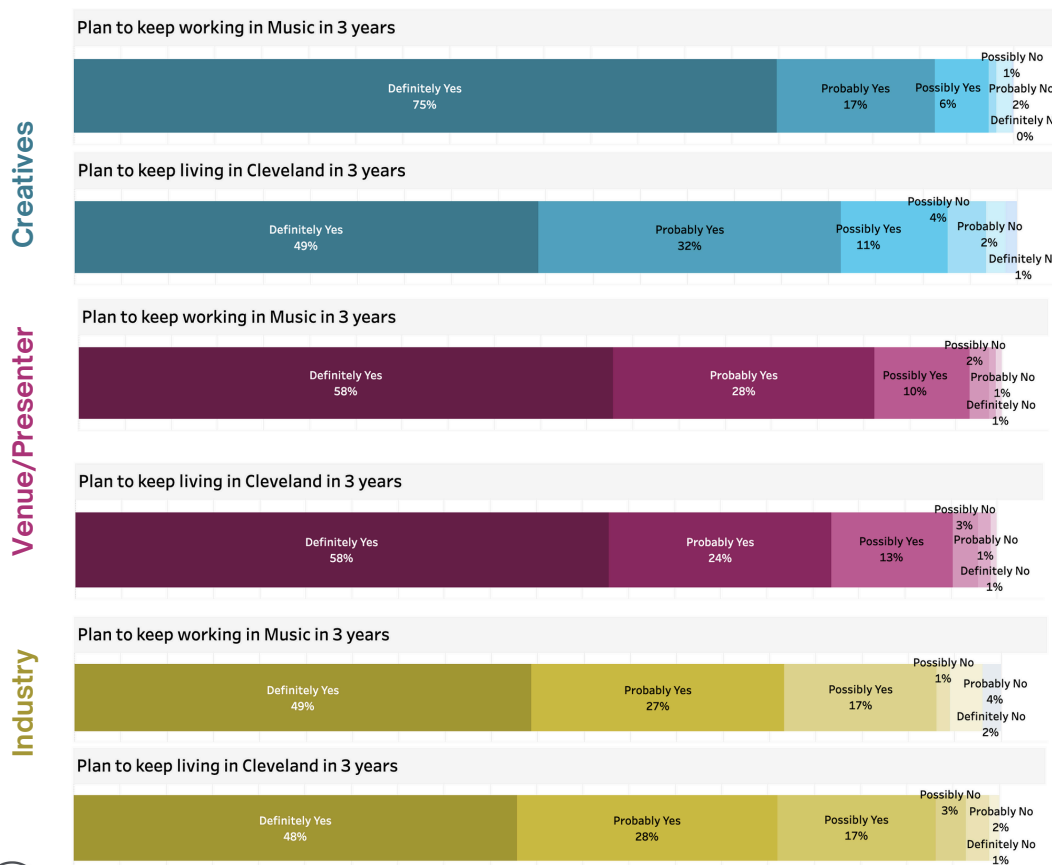
Ecosystem Composition (continued)



- Gender** - Cleveland's music ecosystem shows a gender imbalance, with people who identify as male comprising 69% and female 27% of respondents overall. While the industry sector exhibits a closer gender split (53% male, 43% female), venues/presenters skew more towards males (61% male, 36% female). The creative sector presents the most significant disparity, with 74% male and 22% female representation.



- Sexual Orientation** - Primarily heterosexual or straight (78%), although 8% prefer not to say.



- Continuing in Music** - Creatives are the most committed (75-92%); venues/presenters are also in (58-86%); and industry is least committed but still enthusiastic (49-76%).

- Staying in Cleveland** - Venues/presenters are understandably the most committed to staying in Cleveland (58-82%); creatives are slightly more dedicated (49-81%) than industry (49-77%).

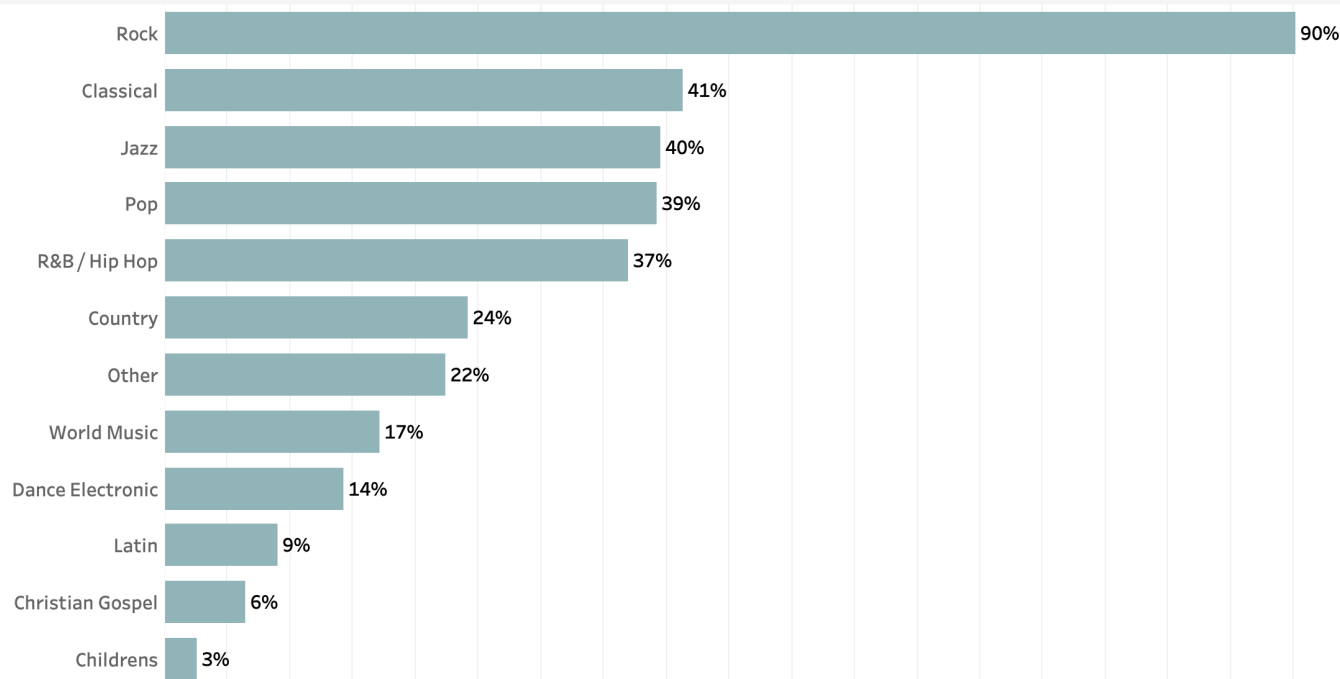
Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Creative Profile

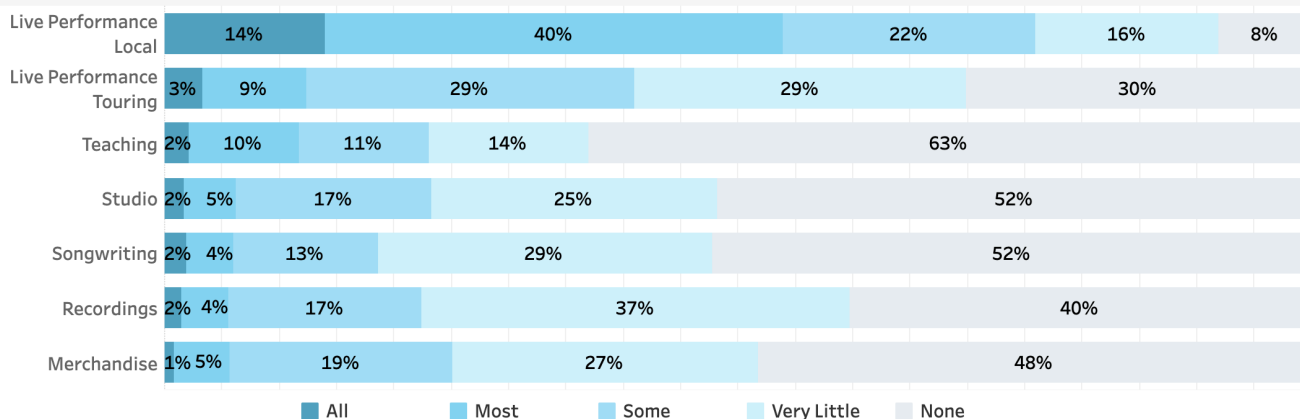
Cleveland's diverse musical genres span rock, classical, jazz, pop, and R&B/hip hop. Creatives rely primarily on local gigs for income, while other sources like touring and studio work are less substantial; there is a need for diversification of revenue streams.

- **Genre** - Respondents overwhelmingly associate Cleveland's music with rock (90%), classical (41%), jazz (40%), pop (39%), R&B/Hip Hop (37%), as well as country (24%) and other types of music.
- **Income sources** - Local live performances are a major income stream for 54% of creatives. Touring is less significant, with only 12% earning most, and 29% earning some from tours. Teaching and studio work, including recordings and songwriting, play smaller roles in financial support.

Which genres of music do you associate with Cleveland?



Creative: Sources of Income

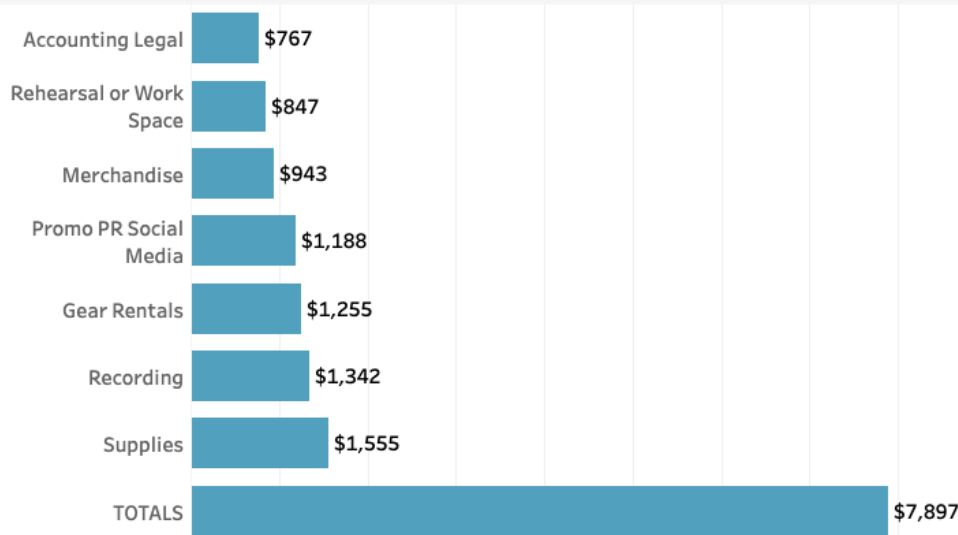


Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Creative Profile (continued)

- **Spend** - Creative respondents annually spend approximately \$7,897 on music-related services, with half of this expenditure staying local. Their spending is notably higher than in Austin, where the average is \$6,300. Collectively, creative respondents contribute around \$29.58 million to the economy each year, with 48% of that amount circulating locally. Significant expenses include recording, which tops the list at \$5.16 million, followed closely by promotion and social media, rehearsal and workspace, and supplies, each exceeding \$4 million in total spend.

Creative Expenses Annually - Average



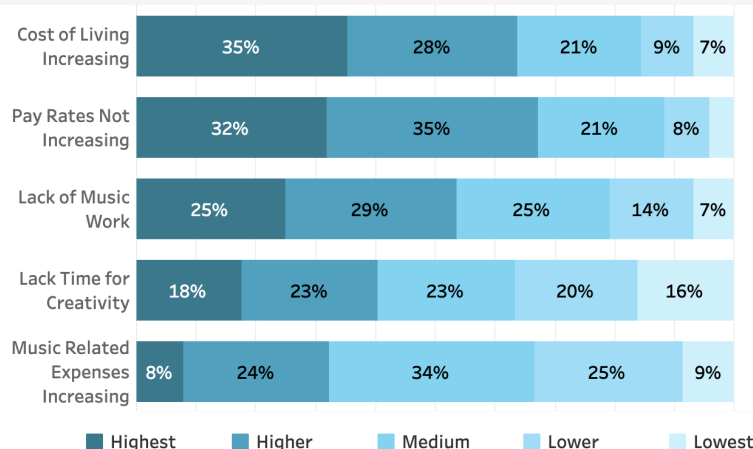
\$7,897
Average Creative Spend

\$22M
Total Creative
Respondents Spend
Annually

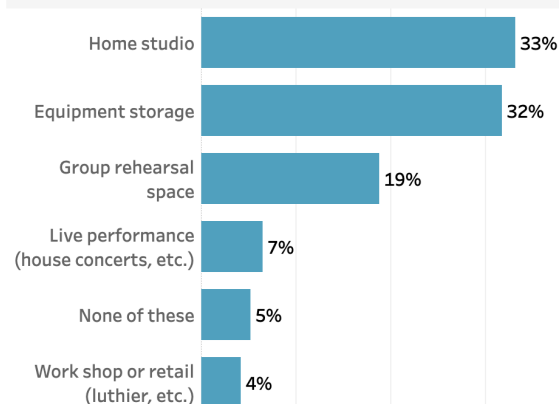
48%
Spent Locally

- **Housing** - Creatives predominantly use their homes for music-related activities: 33% for home studios, 32% for equipment storage, 19% for rehearsals, and 7% for live performances. They are generally located near the city center, though some are in densely populated areas further out.
- **Concerns** - The main concerns for creatives are the cost of living (35%), stagnant pay rates (32%), and a scarcity of music work (25%), indicating that affordability is likely to become a pressing issue.

Creative Career Concerns



Home Use for Music Work

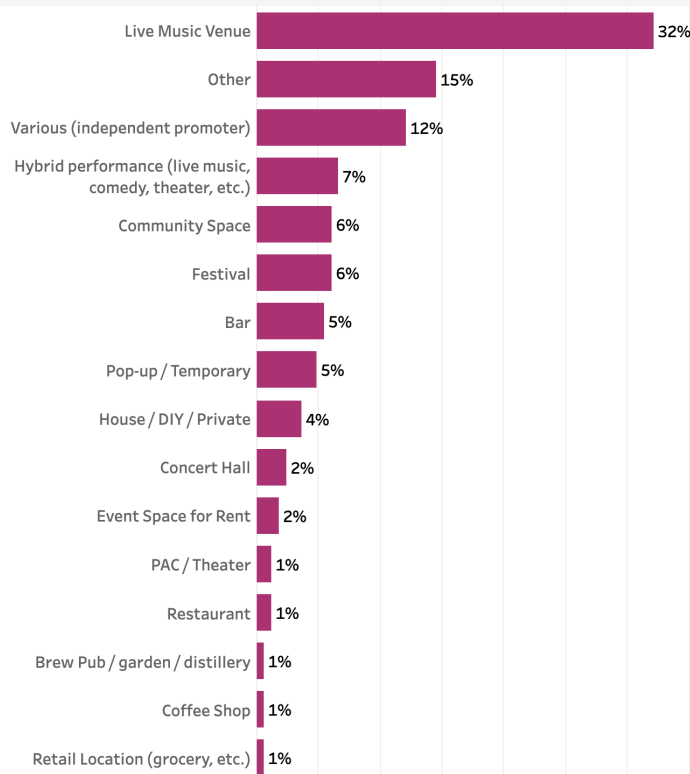


Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Venue/Presenter Profile

Of the ~220 venues/presenter respondents, the majority (32%) identify as a live music venue, 12% identify as independent promoters, with community space and festivals coming in at 6%. The types of venues and presenters show an extensive live music scene. Venues average 91 live events/year for a total of 14,762 total live events.

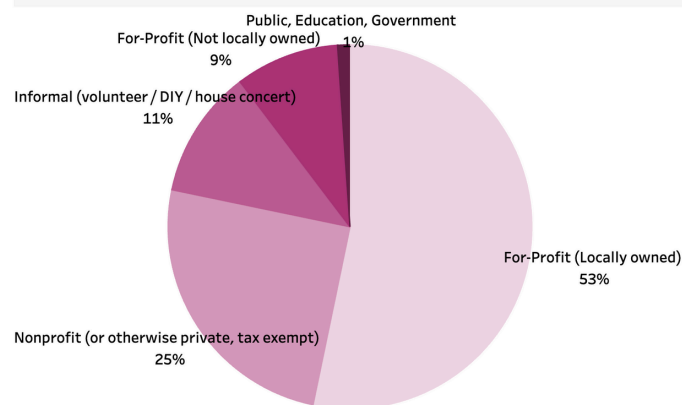
Venue/Presenter Type



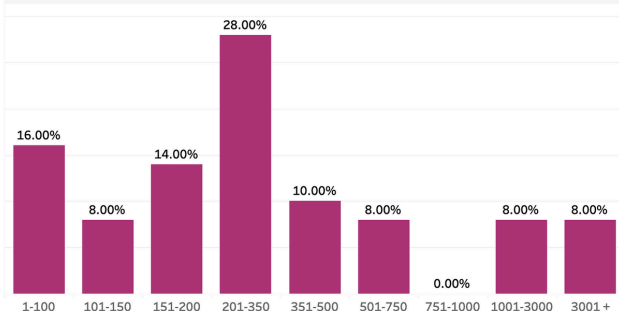
- **Venue Ownership/Tax Structure** - Healthy and diverse with primarily locally owned for profit (53%) and nonprofit (25%).

- **Venue Capacity and Capabilities** - Spans a broad range, although 750-1000 capacity venues are non-existing according to respondents. Good number of venues with outdoor capabilities at 66%. Most venues/presenters meet 5 of the 6 factors of defining a live music venue.

Venue/Presenter Ownership (Tax) Structure



Venue Capacity - Owner



Venues average

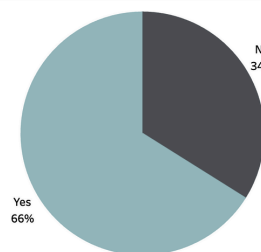
91

live events/year

14,762

total live events/year

Outdoor Capabilities



Venue/Presenters Resources Capabilities



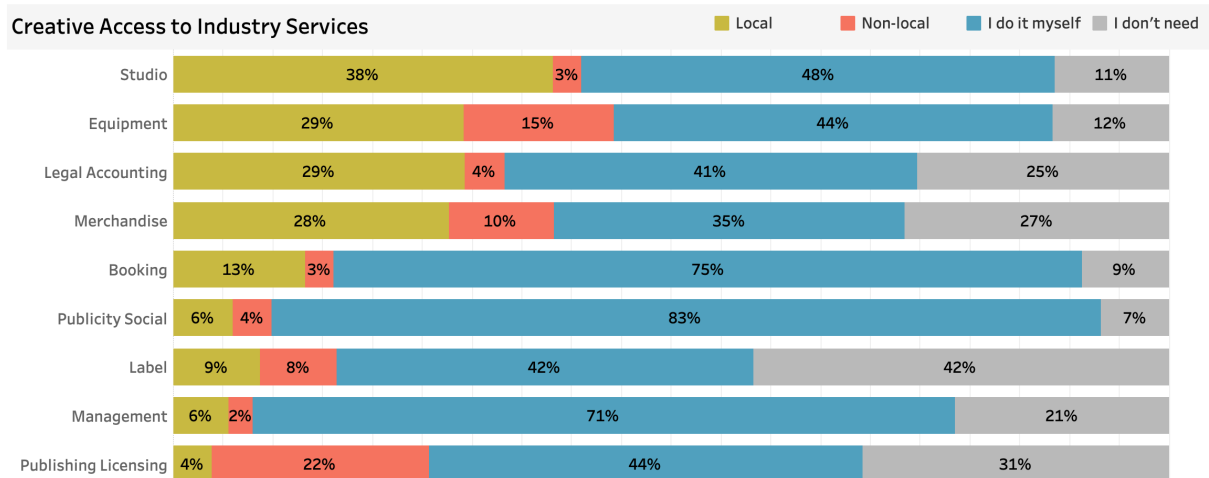
Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Industry Profile

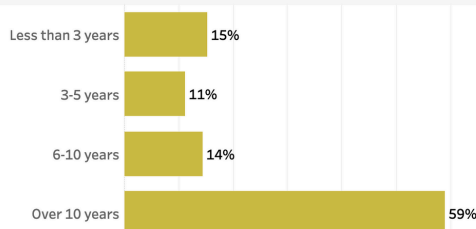
Primary occupations are in event/venue worker among respondents (17%), with music marketing and production support both coming in respectably at 15%.

- **Entry Level Work** - New entrants (15% less than 3 years' experience and 11% with 3-5 years) signals growth and opportunity.
- **Local Demand** - Industry is primarily serving local clients and offerings with the highest uptake among local creatives include studios (38%), equipment (29%), legal/accounting (29%) and merchandise (28%).
- **DIY** - Creatives are doing the majority of industry services themselves, especially publicity/social (83% DIY), booking (75% DIY), and management (71% DIY).

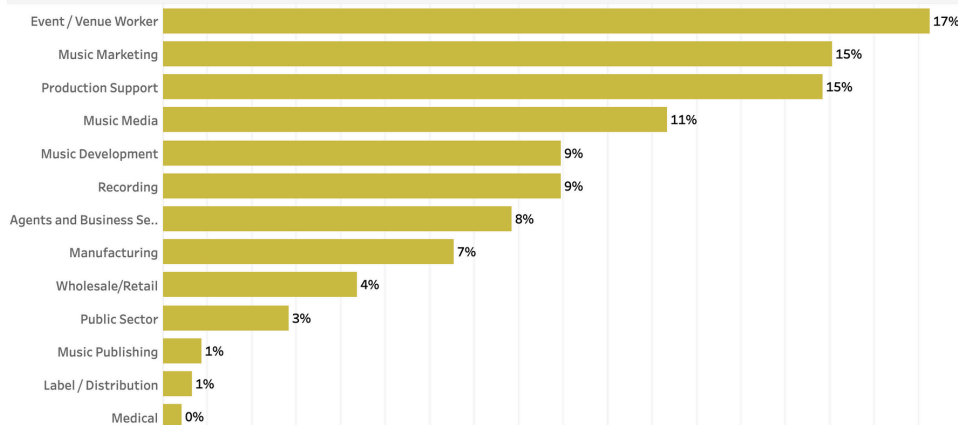
Creative Access to Industry Services



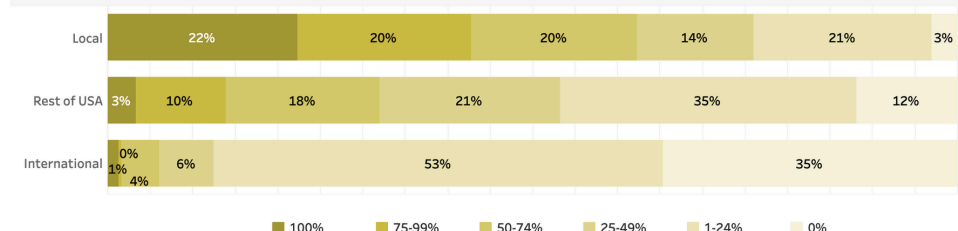
Experience - Industry



Industry Current Occupation



Location of Clients Served by Music Industry



“Poor professional infrastructure. No management, booking agents (for touring), live show developers.”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Economic Activity

Primarily a freelance, independent workforce. 51% freelance, solo, or sole proprietor, 47% band, 28% registered business, and 17% work for businesses that have 6 or more employees.

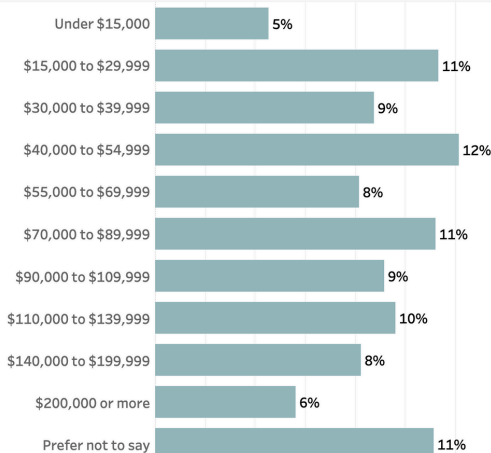
Music generates a total of **\$58M** in income annually across all respondents

26% of respondent annual income comes from music

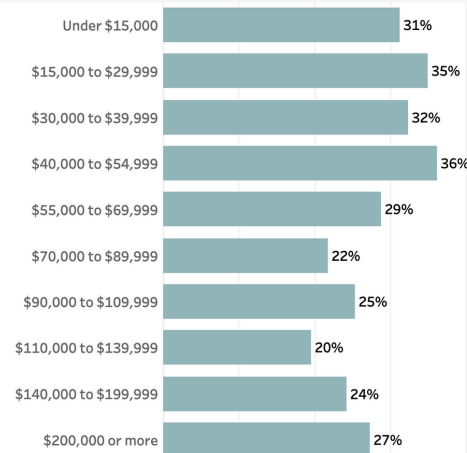
Average household income for respondents is **\$82K**

Average annual income from music is **\$21K**

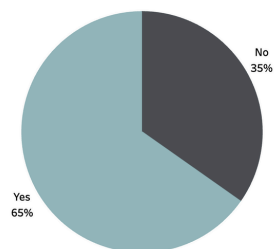
Household Income



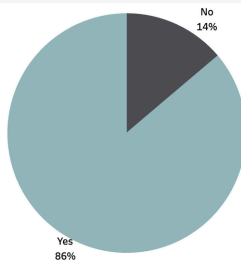
% of Income from Music by Income Bucket



Work Outside of Music

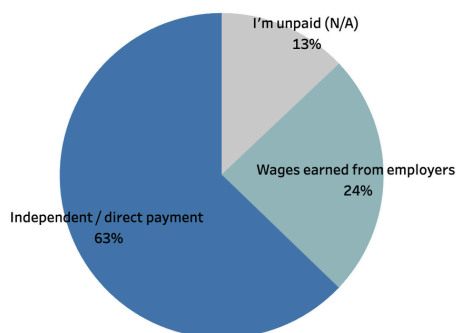


Of those who work outside of music, Outside Job Provides Primary Income

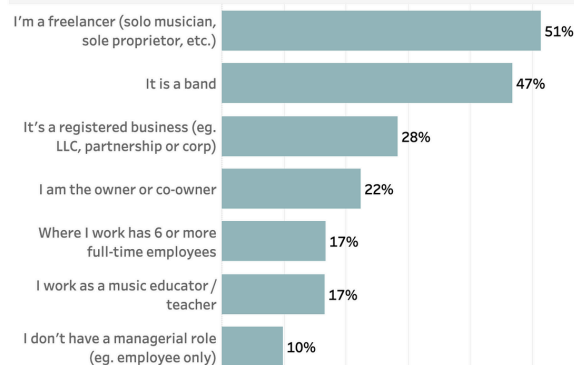


Music Job Compensation Type

Years Experience in Music
(All)



Music Job Type



Outside Work Motivation

Income Security: Not enough earnings from music alone 88%	Benefits: health insurance, retirement, etc. 52%	Flexibility: allows time to still pursue music career 36%	Work/Life Balance: prefer to keep my music separate from work (e.g. hobby) 26%
		Career Development: occupational interest, skills, training outside of music 34%	

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Economic Activity (continued)

- **Creative income** - Musicians rely on local gigs, which generally provide less than \$1000/month income (average pay per local gig \$307, average pay touring gig \$311). Diversifying revenue streams is needed.
- **Venue/Presenter** - Respondents average 91 events per year for a total of 14,762 events annually. 61% feature local headliners, and 74% book all or most local acts as headliner support, with a strong desire to book more local talent (74%).

Venues average

91

live events/year

14,762

total live events/year

\$307

average pay/local gig

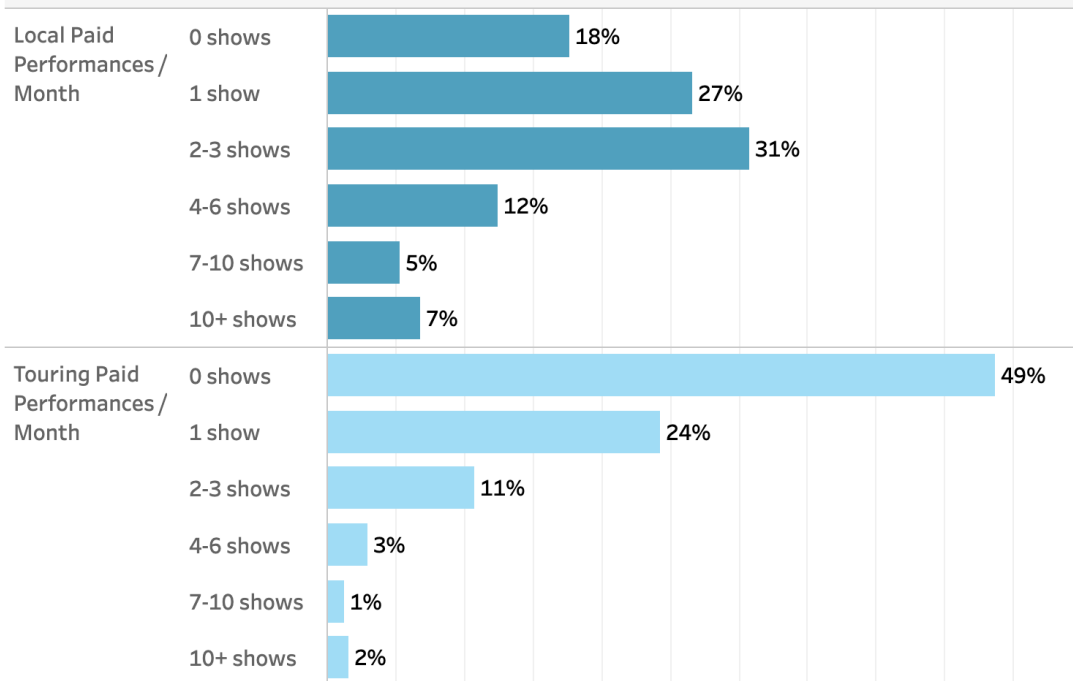
\$311

average pay/touring gig

“ Create opportunities for musicians to get paid regular gigs. ”

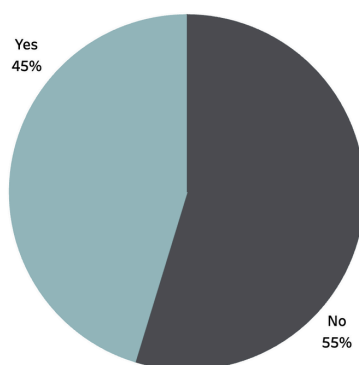
“ Invest in venues and local, original music. Stop only hiring tribute acts. ”

Creative Paid Performances / Month

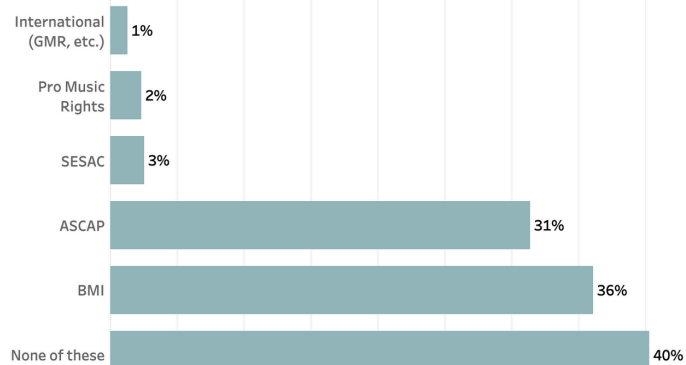


- **Licensing** - 45% are IP rights holders of which 54% don't collect royalties or licensing fees, and of those who do, BMI and ASCAP are dominant methods. 20% work with a publisher and 19% have a provider that handles. These numbers for income from licensing are low, and unfortunately similar in most cities.

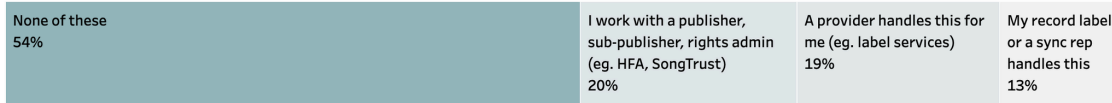
IP Rightsholder



Royalty Collection Methods



Licensing



Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Ecosystem Development

Cleveland Music Ecosystem wants to connect:

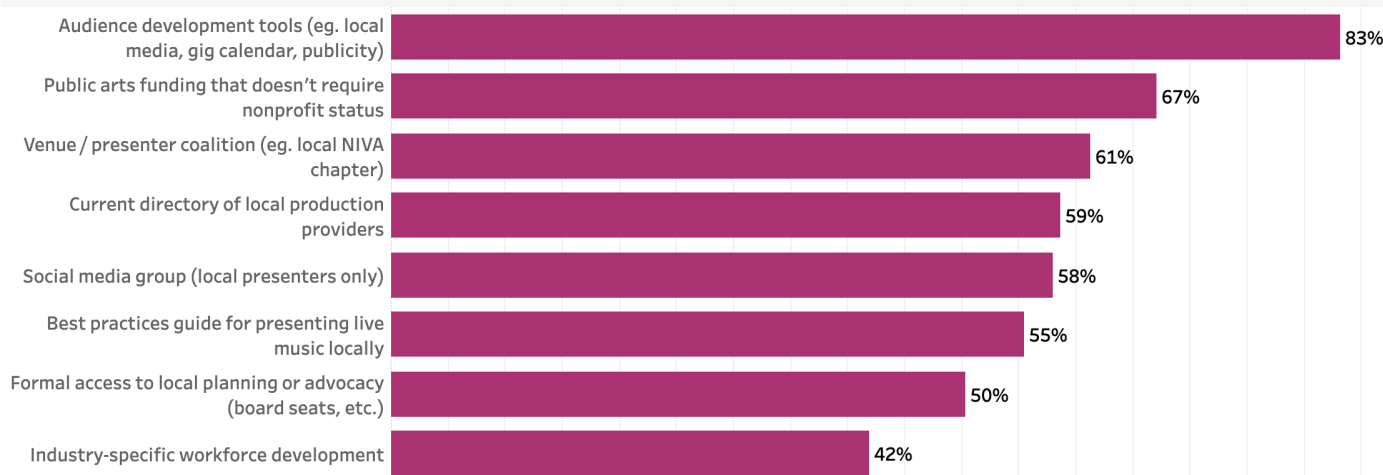
- 60% want a place to connect with music services
- 50% want a place to connect and collaborate musically
- 50% want a place to connect with other creative industries
- 42% want both virtually and in-person community networking

Local Music Resource Preference

A place to connect with music services (agency, record label, artist management, publicity, business, etc.) 60%	A place to connect and collaborate musically 50%	Affordable rehearsal space 39%	Professional Training (music industry specific) 32%
A place to connect with other creative industries (film/video, design, tech, gaming, etc.) 50%	Both virtual and in-person community networking 42%	Studio space and equipment for content creation 37%	Not needed, or already happening. 14%

- **Venues/Presenters** - Seek resources for audience development tools (83%) and public arts funding that doesn't require nonprofit status (67%), venue/presenter coalition (61%), directory of local production providers (59%), best practice guide for presenting live music locally (55%).

Venue/Presenters Preference for Business Resources

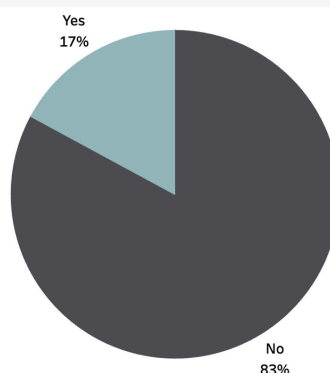


Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Ecosystem Development (continued)

- **Financial Support - 83%** have never received financial assistance for their music work, primarily because of lack of awareness (54%) and lack of grant writing skills (18%). Types of financial assistance preferred include tax breaks of any sort (49%), micro grants (48%), and discounted or no cost services (41%).

History of Financial Assistance for Music Work

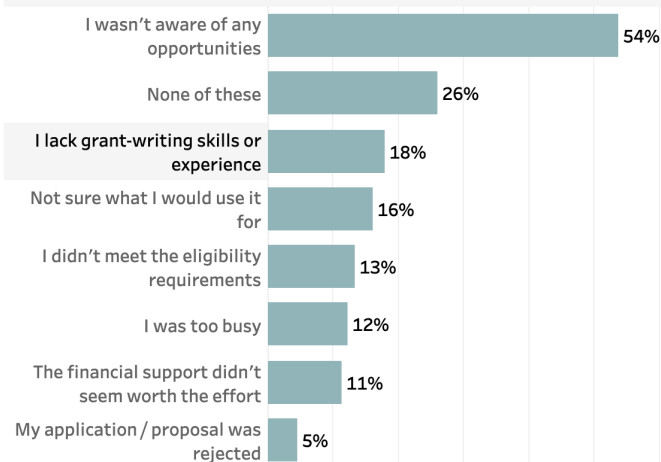


“Give us access to grants to afford to do what we do.”

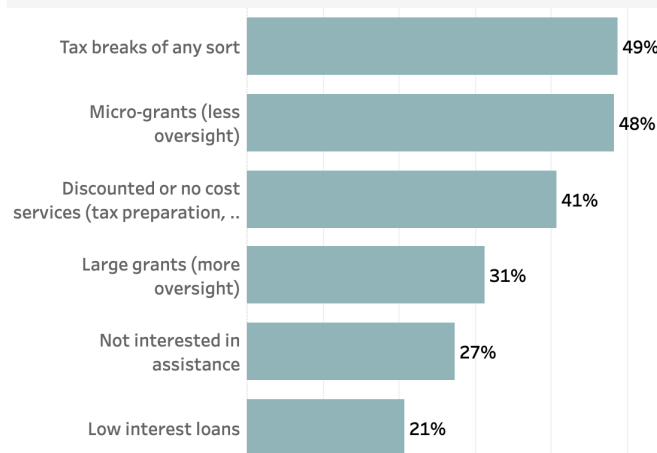
“Tax-free venue ownership, tax breaks for sales trends, sacrifices made for community.”

“Tax incentives for using local talent. Provide low-cost or open public space for music performances.”

Financial Assistance Barrier



Financial Assistance Preference



- **Cleveland Music Marketing** - Respondent comments identified the need to promote local music.

“Promote the unusually high caliber of Cleveland musicians, as a whole.”

“Promote venues, use local music in advertising and promotional items on social media, advocate for artists.”

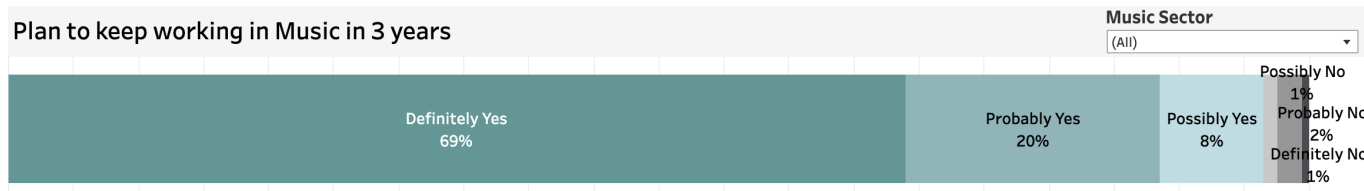
“There's not much coverage available for the events taking place unless there's a financial budget for promotion.”

“Make local music desirable.”

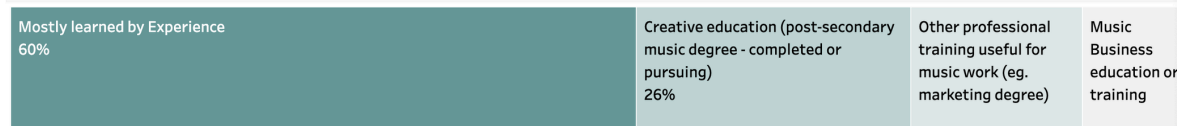
Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Workforce Development

A super majority (69-94%) plan to keep working in music. While the ecosystem is dominated by people who have been working in the music ecosystem for over 10 years (72%), there is a healthy new entrant pipeline in a mostly self or experientially taught workforce (60%).



Formal Music Education



“We need more opportunities for people to develop their skills in public”

Experience

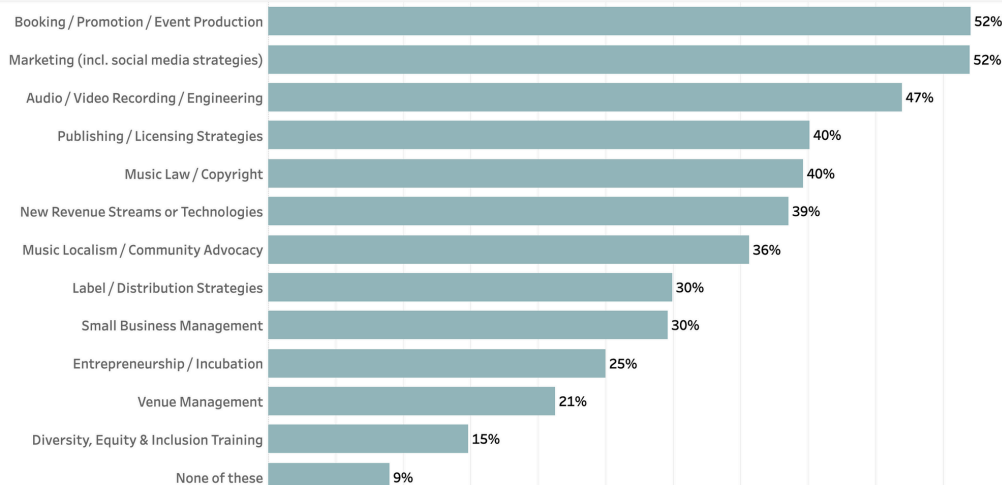


“The most important thing is exposure in the scene and having the opportunity to play quality shows.”

Professional Development

- A super majority of respondents are interested in various levels of professional development training with only 9% that stated they did not need any training. Key topics in demand include booking/promotion/event production and marketing leading at (52%), audio/video recording/engineering (47%).

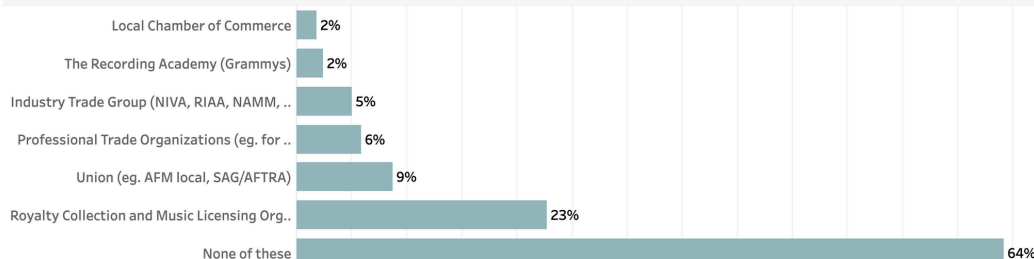
Professional Development Training Skill Preference



Professional Industry Associations

- 64% of respondents do not participate in any professional industry associations, slightly higher than we normally see.

Registrations Memberships

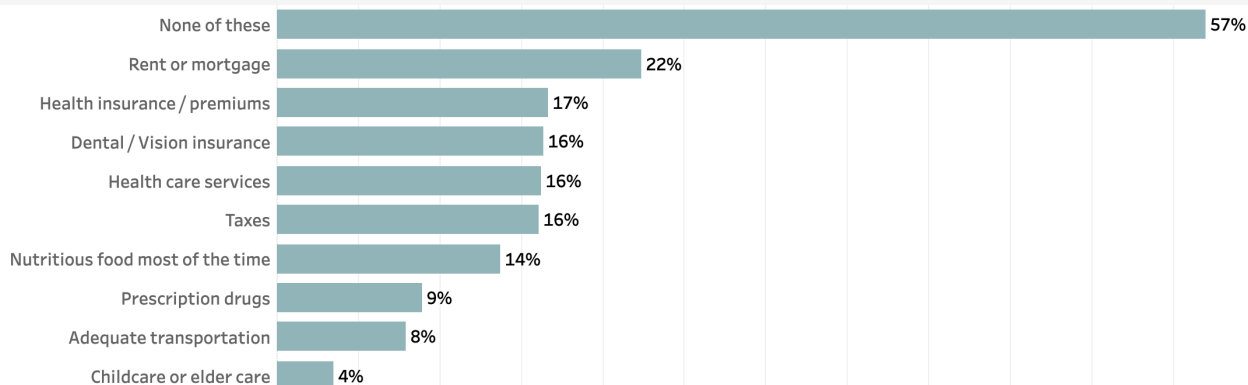


Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Livability

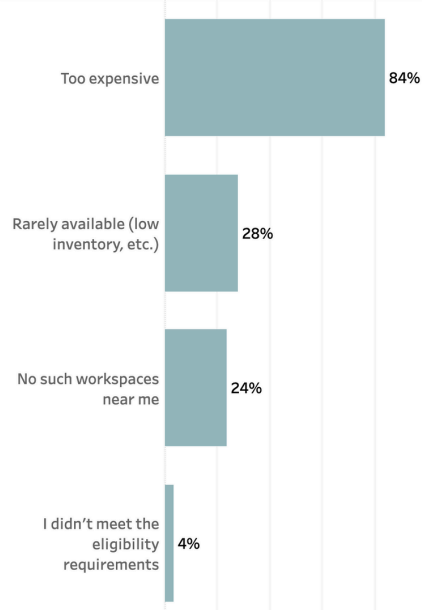
Cleveland respondents find it very livable. 57% have no affordability struggles, 66% own current housing, 58% report no housing changes in the last 3 years, and 91% have health insurance.

Affordability Struggles

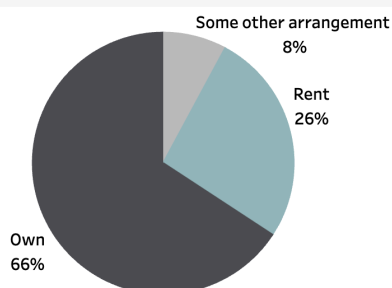


- **Workspace** - 84% report that securing workspace is too expensive, and the main workspace needed is studio space (29%).
- **Housing** - 66% of respondents own their housing, 26% rent, and 8% have some other e. Rent or mortgage struggles 22% foreshadow a livability challenge that may be coming to Cleveland, noting 5% of respondents moved to Cleveland in the last 3 years.

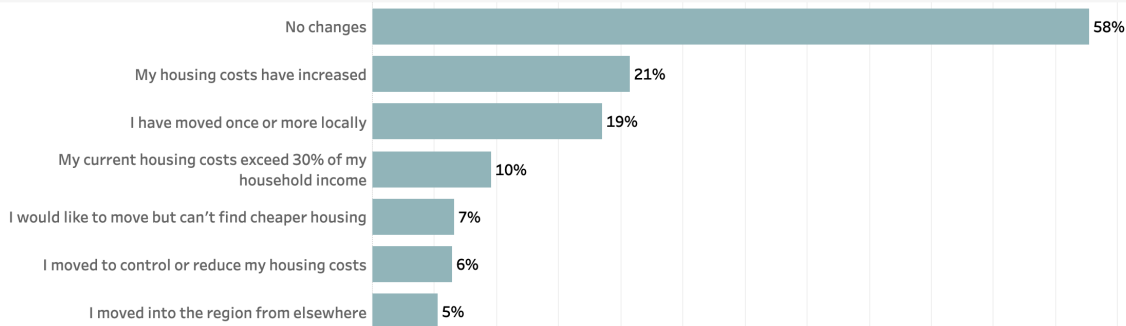
Barriers to Securing Workspace



Current Housing



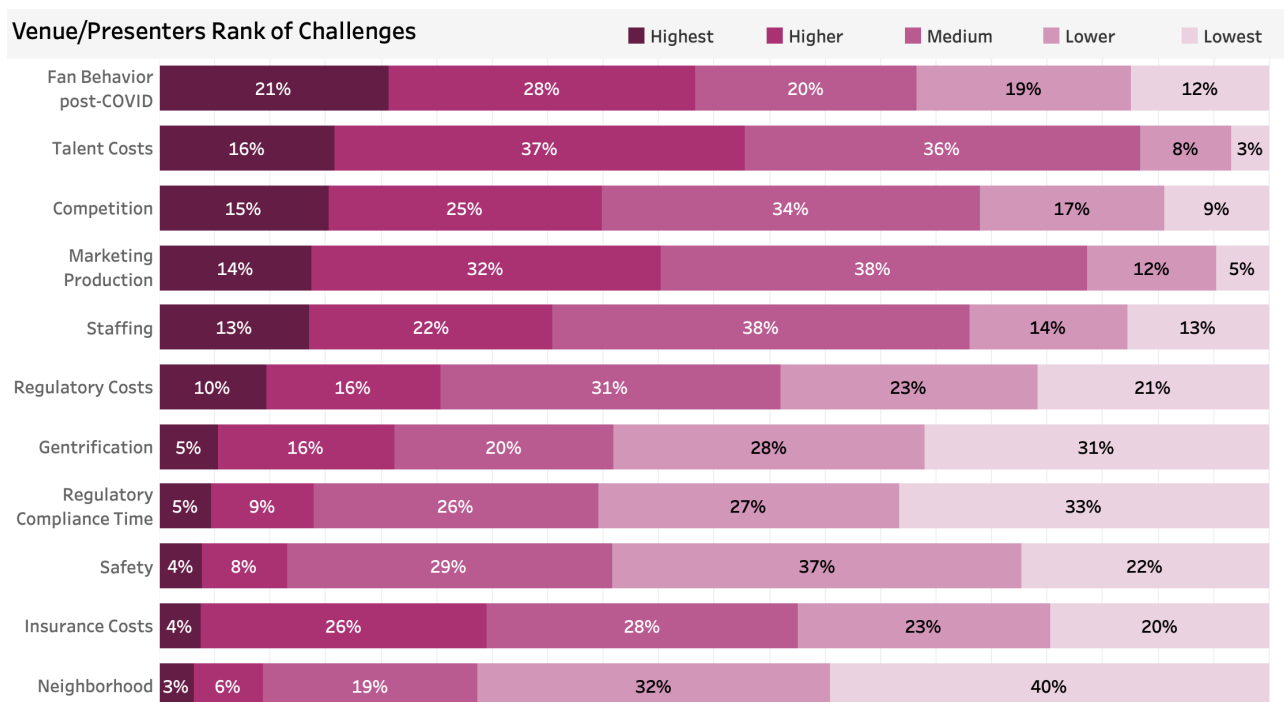
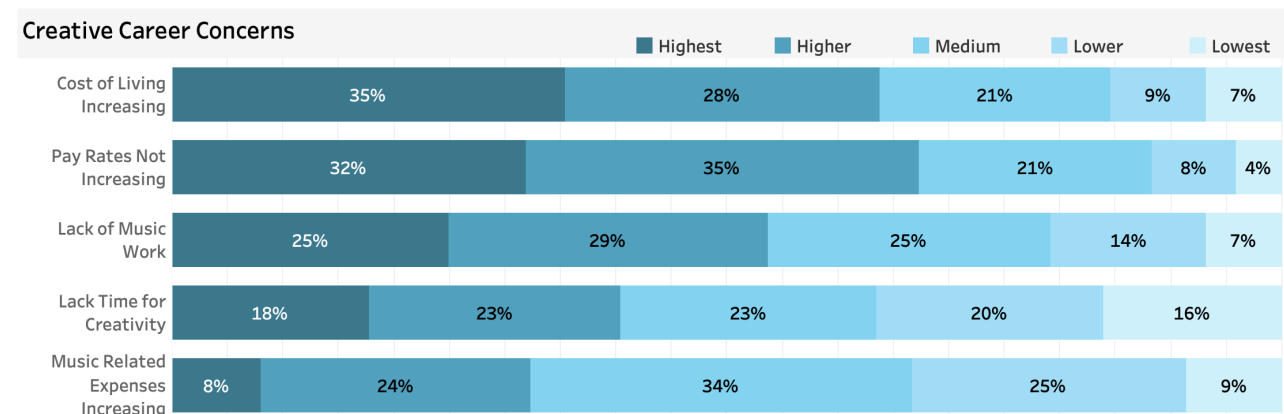
Housing Changes (in last 3 years)



Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Livability (continued)

- **Career Concerns** - Biggest career challenge for Cleveland music people is low or uncertain pay (86%) and lack of benefits (72%) which is consistent with the workforce in music being a largely independent workforce where 65% work another non-music job for income and benefits that they cannot find in music. Creatives are concerned about the cost of living increasing while pay rates not increasing. Venues are concerned about post pandemic fan behavior, talent cost, competition, and marketing production.

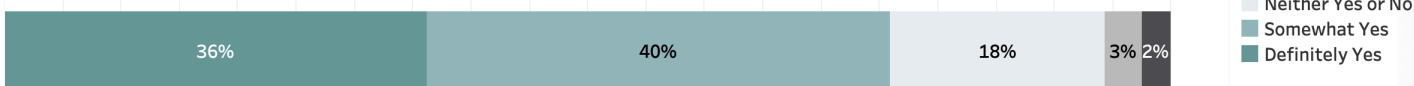


Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Music-Friendly Policies

Majority of respondents (76%) would like to see Cleveland create a music commission. No major policy barriers, although reducing administrative costs and simplifying processes is desired. 66% of venue/presenters enjoy outdoor capabilities.

Do you think Greater Cleveland's music ecosystem would benefit from more formalized advocacy (eg. a music commission)?

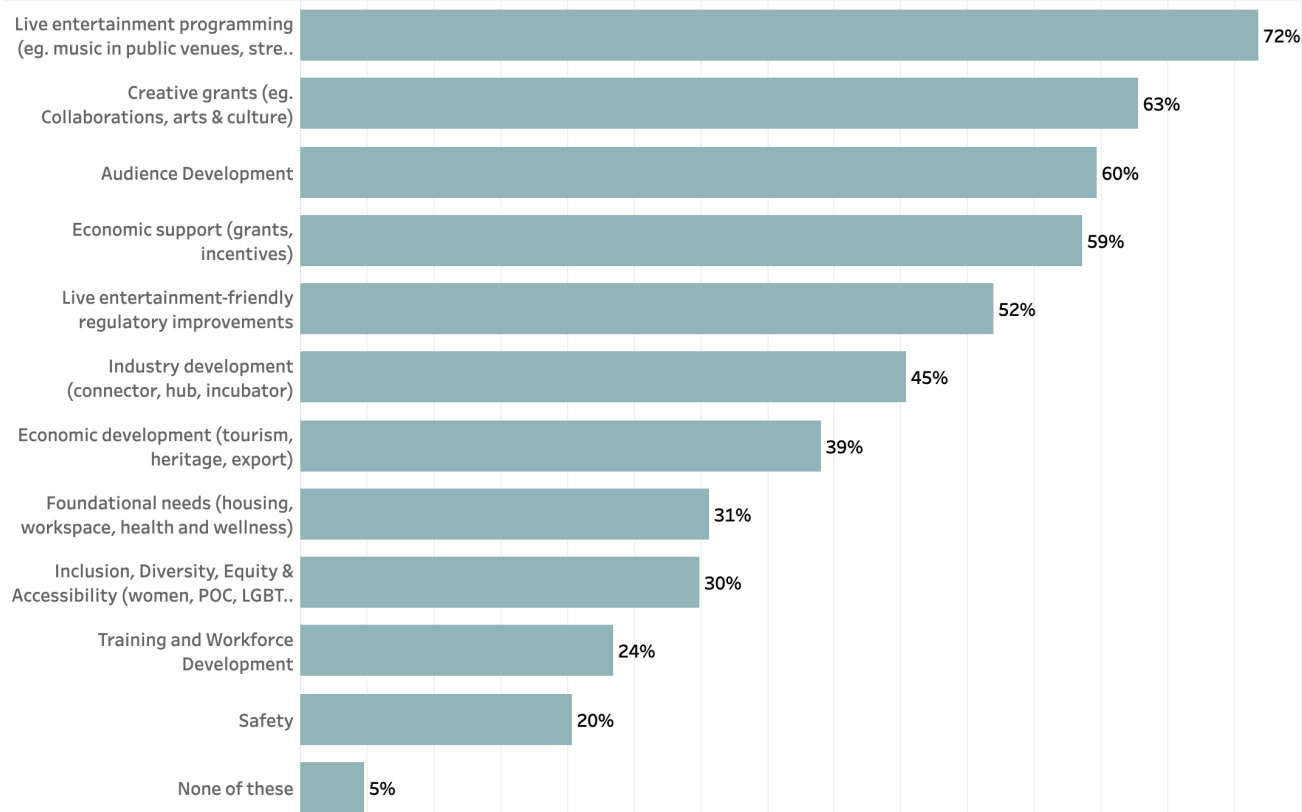


- Music Commission** - 76% of respondents agree that Cleveland would benefit from more formalized advocacy, like a music commission. Focus of such a commission would be: live entertainment programming (eg. music in public venues, streets, festivals, airport) - 72%; creative grants (eg. collaborations, arts & culture) - 63%; audience development - 60%; ecosystem support (grants, incentives) - 59%; and live entertainment-friendly regulatory improvements - 52%.

"Include more music entertainment in local events, establish a music commission to boost music tourism and artist development."

A dedicated commission at both the city and county level.

Which of the following efforts would you want such advocacy, such as a music commission, to focus its resources?

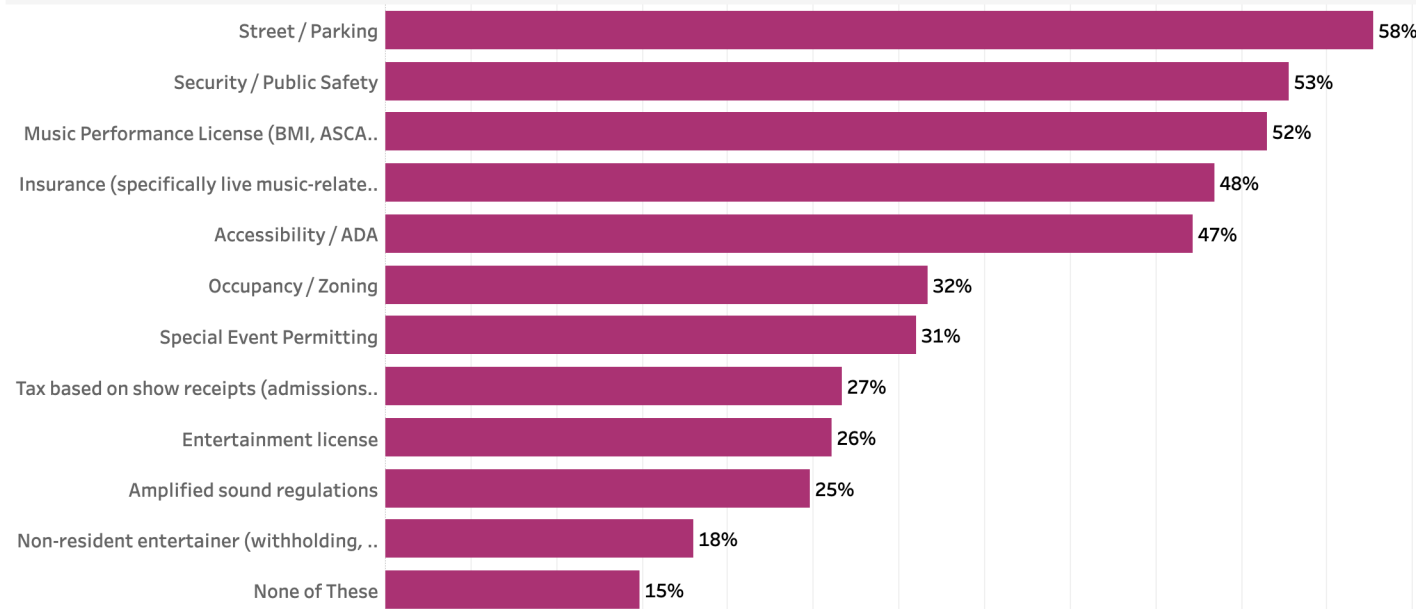


Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Music-Friendly Policies (continued)

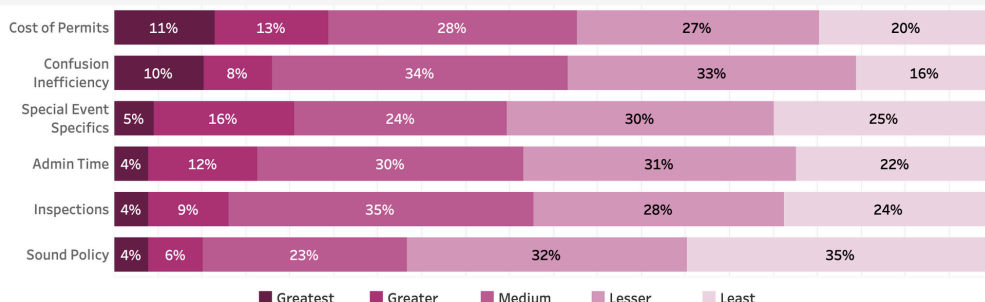
- **Regulatory Processes** - Venue/Presenters fluency with regulatory processes shows low to moderate exposure (street/parking is the highest 58%, and security/public safety 53%). There is variable experience across different regulatory processes, noting that 15% had no experience with any of the required regulatory processes. This tells us that there is an opportunity for city and county governments to enhance their relationship with the music sector by hosting venue/presenter summits for better outreach and education.

Venue/Presenters Live Entertainment Required Regulatory Processes



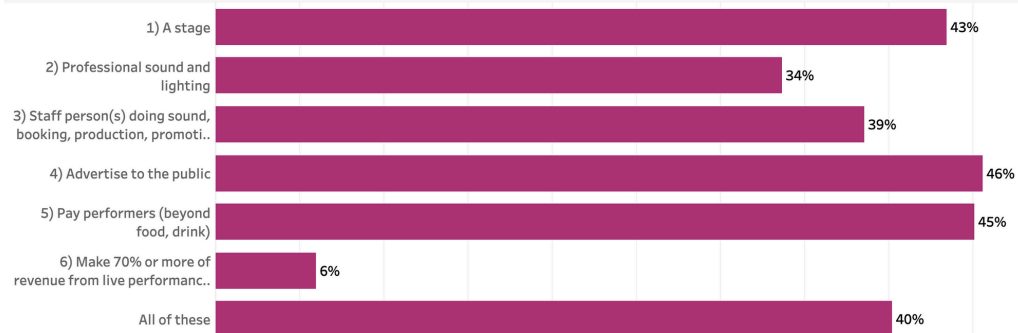
- **Regulatory Challenges** - 52% rank cost of permits as a medium to greatest regulatory challenge and 52% cite confusion inefficiency, inspections 48%, special event specifics 45%.

Presenters Rank of Regulatory Challenges



- **Expanded Venue Capabilities** – Only 34% of venues provide professional sound and lighting, and performance infrastructure. Partnerships with city, county grants and private investments could address this need/opportunity.

Venue/Presenters Resources Capabilities



Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

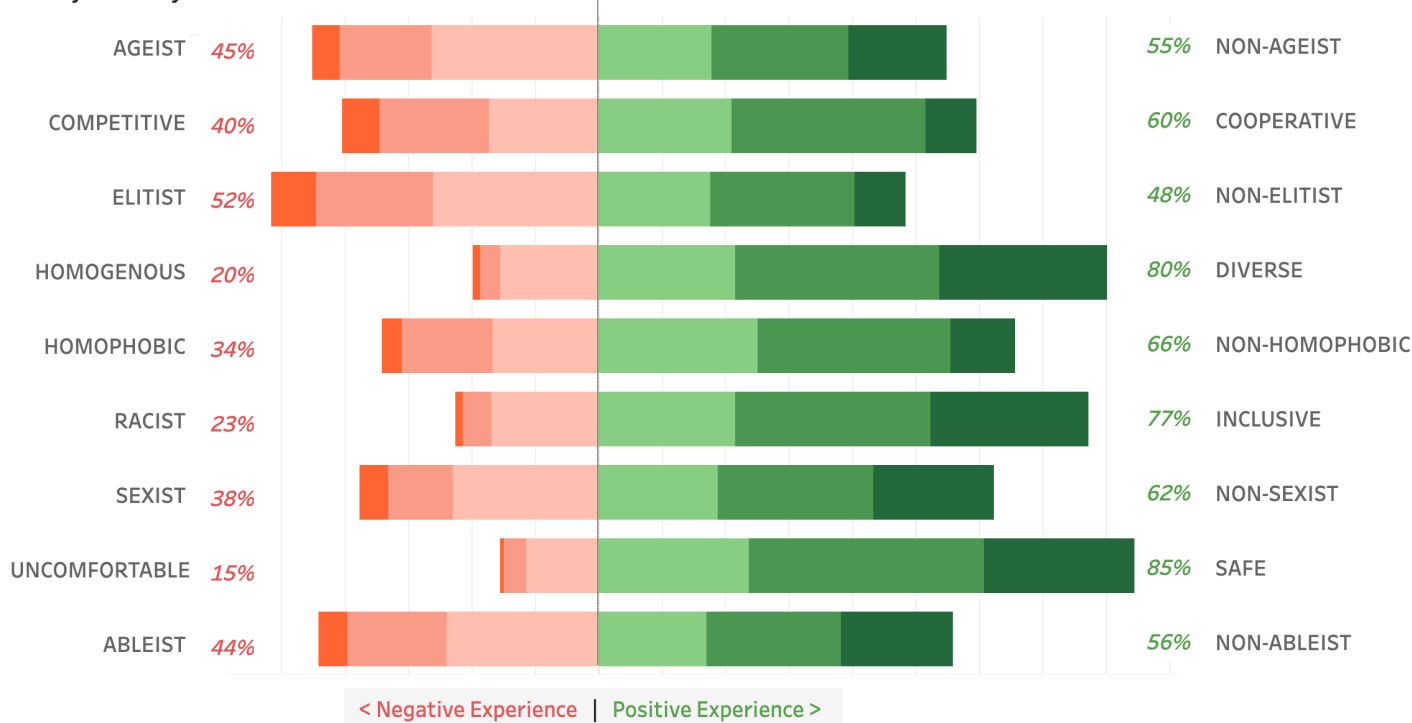
Culture & Belonging

The Cleveland music ecosystem offers mainly positive experiences.

The Cleveland music ecosystem challenges are elitism, ageism, and ableism.

The Cleveland music ecosystem strengths are that it is safe, diverse, and inclusive.

Do you find your local music scene...



Subgroup Insights

Please see the online dashboard at www.ClevelandRocksPPF.org for full data on each indicator by subgroup. Some overarching themes to the subgroups are:

- **Negative experiences** - People who identify as Black and Gay/Lesbian tend to experience the most negative (red) side of the Cleveland music ecosystem.

“Too clique-ish in each genre—very slow to accept newcomers.”

“Effort is being made to promote artists of color, female, and LGBTQ+”

“Cleveland scene is supportive and doing pretty well.”

“Musicians are reinforcing cliques, not allowing 'outsiders' in.”

Key Insights

Low Responses Rates from Black community and 18-24 year olds: Despite efforts, this Census didn't reach the Black community and where it did, there's work to do on culture & belonging. Similarly, it may be due to low participation in this survey, but 18-24 year old respondent rates are low across all segments, which could indicate a need to attract young people to the ecosystem. Whether due to response rates or not, there's a need to focus outreach to both these segments.

Music Commission: There is strong interest in representation for the music ecosystem at the city or county level.

Connecting the Ecosystem: Several data points indicate a desire for connecting across the ecosystem, especially a music hub offering collaboration among musicians and connections with other creative sectors.

Performance Opportunities: Music creatives in Cleveland are seeking more opportunities to perform. This may be due to a need for more festivals, lack of incentives to feature local live music, or other factors, but creatives are looking for stages.

Financial Assistance: For respondents, only 17% have received any form of financial assistance, and yet music generates a total of \$58M annually. A range of financial assistance, tax breaks, or incentives could further increase the local economy of the Cleveland music ecosystem.

Audience Development: Creatives and Venues & Presenters express the need for support in marketing Cleveland's music offerings to locals and visitors.

Ample Industry: Cleveland has a decent industry segment (18%) that is approaching 20% which offers its ecosystem a competitive advantage over places lacking this infrastructure. Growing this segment, incentivizing innovative approaches, and increasing awareness and outreach to local audiences, many of whom provide industry services for themselves (DIY), would grow this important segment and keep dollars local, further boosting the music economy in Cleveland.

Livable Place: Cleveland respondents find it very livable with some affordability challenges looming.



Photo Courtesy of Cleveland Rocks Past, Present, Future

Opportunities

Financial Support and Economic Incentives

- Direct Financial Assistance: Implement grants, crowdfunding, sponsorship programs, direct payments (e.g., stipends), and tax incentives to support musicians, venues, and events financially. Given low rates of awareness and grant writing experience, this effort will need to be accompanied by a campaign for awareness and design of an easy, simple application.
- Support for Venues: Enhance venue infrastructure through funding, tax breaks, and operational assistance, ensuring venues can overcome financial and regulatory challenges. There is a strong desire for public arts funding that doesn't require nonprofit status, noting that 75% of venues/presenters are not nonprofits.
- Incentive program: Incentives/tax rebate/grants to qualified businesses that host local live performances (reference model: Performing Arts Promotion Amendment Act in Washington D.C. offers property tax rebates to businesses who satisfy the requirements of number of performances and performer pay).

Community and Market Development

- Promotional and Marketing Support: Increase promotional efforts, including partnerships with local media and strategic social media use, to raise the profile of local music.
- Expand Performance Opportunities: Foster more live performance platforms such as pop-up concerts, street performances, community festivals, and the creation of public performance spaces.
- Diverse and Inclusive Event Programming: Promote a wider range of music events, focusing on inclusivity and diversity to attract diverse artists and audiences.

Community Engagement and Governance

- Strengthen Community Engagement: Enhance efforts to support underrepresented groups and foster a collaborative environment, reducing competitiveness and exclusivity.
- Establish a Music Commission: Set up a dedicated body at the city or county level to coordinate with stakeholders, advise on policy, and host public forums for community input and oversight. Help facilitate conversations to improve regulatory challenges/costs/confusion in a public manner.

Regulatory and Operational Improvements

- Improve Venue and Event Quality: Invest in maintaining and upgrading venues, especially sound systems and lighting. This could be facilitated through partnerships with the city, grants, and private investments.
- Reduce Bureaucratic Barriers: Decrease permit costs and simplify the regulatory environment for music events and businesses to allow for easier operations and growth. A City-led venue/presenter summit would enhance communication and develop fluency and proficiency with regulatory requirements and processes.



Photos Courtesy of Cleveland Rocks Past, Present, Future

Opportunities (continued)

Connecting the Music Community

- Music Hubs - virtual and physical space: A series of smaller hubs utilizing existing spaces, such as venues and other cultural and creative spaces. These hubs would provide a nexus for music services, collaboration among musicians, and connections with other creative sectors. They could also offer essential resources like affordable rehearsal areas, professional training, and studio space/equipment for content creation. Additionally, these hubs would serve as venues for both virtual and in-person networking, supporting the community's desire for a versatile and accessible musical environment.
- Mentorship: With so many people with 10+ years experience, and older folks experiencing elitism/ageism, mentorship initiatives could plug in the experience across the ecosystem in a meaningful way. If this were implemented across different sectors, there could be opportunities to convert the DIY into doing it together.

Revenue Development

- Music Export Initiative: Establish a music export initiative that creates opportunities for Cleveland musicians to showcase their music outside of the city, which drives tourism, talent attraction and economic development, while giving artists a needed engine and platform to grow their careers and elevate Cleveland's profile as a music city.
- Diversify Revenue Streams: Educate artists to tap into a spectrum of over 300 potential revenue streams, including digital content creation, merchandise sales, and more to build a more resilient financial base.

Professional Development

- Educational and Professional Development: Offer workshops, seminars, and investments in music education to build business acumen and skills among musicians and venue owners. Venue/presenters are seeking audience development tools and best practices guides for presenting live music locally.



Photo Courtesy of Cleveland Rocks Past, Present, Future